4NG Fanatics

Equus

By Peter Shaffer

INTRODUCTION

In this selection, a psychiatrist, Martin Dysart, investigates the savage blinding of six horses with a metal spike. The atrocity was committed by an unassuming seventeen-year-old stable boy named Alan Strang, the only son of an opinionated father and a genteel, religious mother. Alan is found guilty, but mentally disturbed, and he is sentenced to an inpatient ward at Rokesby Psychiatric Hospital. Can Dr. Dysart discover the motive behind Alan's brutal actions; can Alan be saved from himself? Equus by Peter Shaffer.

DYSART: **(Pg 21-23)** Hallo. I'm pleased to meet you *(he puts out his hand. Alan does not respond in any way. Dysart opens his file)* Is this your full name? Alan Strang? *(Silence)* And you're seventeen. Is that right? Seventeen? . . . . Well?

ALAN: *(singing low)* Double your pleasure, Double your fun, With Doublemint, Doublemint, Doublemint gum. *(See note at the end of this selection for a link to the Doublemint jingle)*

DYSART: *(unperturbed)* Now, let's see. You work in an electrical shop during the week. You live with your parents.

ALAN: *(approaching him, hostile but still singing)* Double your pleasure, Double your fun, With Doublemint, Doublemint, Doublemint gum.

DYSART: *(appreciatively)* That's a good song. Please do that one again. *(Silence. The boy glares at him; Dysart speaks to audience)* **(Pg 26-29)** It took him two more days of commercials, and then he snapped. He burts in – just like that – without knocking or anything. Fortunately I didn't have a patient with me.

ALAN: *(belligerently)* [My mother] knows more than you. I bet I do too. I bet I know more history than you . . . Who was the Hammer of the Scots?

DYSART: I don't know: who?

ALAN: King Edward the First. Who never smiled again? *(with hardly a pause to allow the doctor to answer)* It was Henry the First. *(bragging)* I know all the Kings.

DYSART: And who was your favorite?

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ALAN: John . . . he put out the eyes of that smarty little – *(Pause, sensing he has said something wrong)* Well, he didn't really. He was prevented, because the gaoler* was merciful! ***He was prevented! . . .*** Who said "Religion is the opium of the people?" *(giggles inappropriately)*

DYSART: *(to audience)* The odd thing was, he said it with a sort of guilty snigger. The sentence is obviously associated with some kind of tension. It's probably his dad. He may say it to provoke his wife.

ALAN: Mind your own beeswax!

DYSART: *(to audience)* I want[ed] to have a look at his home, so I invited myself over. If there's any tension over religion, it should be evident on a Sabbath evening!

******* Scene breaks to Dysart's meeting with Alan's parents *******

MOTHER: **(pg 30)** It's all so unbelievable, Doctor . . . Alan's always been such a gentle boy. He loves animals! Especially horses. He even has a photograph of one up in his bedroom. **(Pg 45)** It's a most remarkable picture, really. You very rarely see a horse taken from that angel – absolutely head on. It comes out all eyes. **(pg 30-32)** And when he was seven or eight, I used to have to read him the same book over and over, all about a horse. It was called Prince, and no one could ride him. *(Mother steps back in time to a scene with Alan)*

ALAN: *(excited, younger voice)* Why not? . . . Why not? . . . Say it! In his voice. ***Say it! Say it! . . . . Use his voice!***

MOTHER: *('proud' horses voice that will be used by Alan later)* Because I am faithful! *(Alan giggles)* My name is Prince and I'm a prince among horses! Only my young Master can ride me! Anyone else – I'll throw off! *(Alan giggles louder – Mother speaks to both Alan and Dysart simultaneously)* Did you know that when Christian calvary first appeared in the New World, the pagans thought horse and rider was one person?

ALAN: *(amazed)* One person?

MOTHER: Actually, they thought it must be a god.

ALAN: A god!

DYSART: That's fascinating. I never heard that before . . . Can you remember anything else like that you may have told him about horses?

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MOTHER: *(to Dysart)* They're in the Bible, of course. 'He saith among the trumpets, Ha ha' *(The Ha Ha should be a trumpet-like sound)* The Book of Job. Such a noble passage. You know – *(quoting to both Dysart and Alan)* 'Hast thou given the horse strength?'

ALAN: *(responding)* 'Hast thou clothed his neck with thunder?'

MOTHER: 'The glory of his nostrils is terrible!'

ALAN: 'He swallows the ground with fierceness and rage!'

MOTHER: 'He saith among the trumpets – '

ALAN: *(trumpeting)* 'Ha! Ha!' *(and again)* 'Ha! Ha!'

MOTHER: *(to Dysart)* We've always been a horsey family. My grandfather used to ride every morning . . . indulging in equitation, he called it.

ALAN: *(trying the word)* Equitation

MOTHER: *(to Dysart)* I told him how that came from ***equus***, the Latin word for horse. Alan was fascinated by that word.

ALAN: *(savoring it)* Equus!

DYSART: *(turns to Frank)* **(Pg 33 – 35)** Would you say she was closer to him than you are?

FRANK: They've always been thick as thieves. I can't say I entirely approve – especially when I hear her whispering that Bible to him hour after hour, up there in his room. I'm an atheist, and I don't mind admitting it. If you want my opinion, it's the Bible that's responsible for all this . . . A boy spends night after night having this stuff read into him; an innocent man tortured to death – thorns driven into his head – nails into his hands – a spear jammed through his ribs. It can mark anyone for life, that kind of thing. The boy was absolutely fascinated by all that. He was always mooning over religious pictures. I mean real kinky ones, if you receive my meaning. *(Pause)* Bloody religion – it's our only real problem in this house.

ALAN: *(begins to murmur)* Ek! . . . Ek! . . . ***Ek!*** . . .

DYSART: **Pg 46** *(to audience)* It was then – that moment – I felt real alarm.

******* Scene returns to a session between Dysart and Alan ********

DYSART: **(Pg 37-38)** [Alan], what is Ek? *(no response)* [O.K., then] what is your first memory of a horse? How old were you? *(still no response)* I thought you might like to talk about it.

ALAN: *(Singing)* **Pg 23** Double your pleasure, Double your fun,

DYSART: **Pg 37** Come on, now. You can do better than that.

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ALAN: *(Singing louder)* **Pg 23** With Doublemint, Doublemint, Doublemint gum.

DYSART: **Pg 37** All right. We're finished for today.

ALAN: That's not fair! *(Emptily clenching his hands. He turns away, pauses, then sullenly)* On a beach . . . [I was] six **(pg 48)** *(pause – He is in great emotional difficulty)* The horse . . . his sides were all warm, and the smell . . . *(Pause)* When the horse first appeared, I looked up into his mouth. It was huge. There was this chain in it. I said 'Does it hurt?' and he said – the horse said – said – *(He stops in anguish then continues desperately in the voice of the horse)* **(Pg 66-67)** Yes. *(as Alan)* I'll take it out for you. *(as horse)* It never comes out. They have me in chains.

DYSART: Like Jesus? *(silence)* Only his name isn't Jesus, is it? What is it? You can tell me, Alan. Name him.

ALAN: *(with great difficulty and nearly inaudibly)* Equus.

DYSART: Now think of the stable. What is the stable? His Temple? His Holy of Holies?

ALAN: *(quietly)* Yes. *(returning to the present)* **(Pg 48-49)** It was always the same, after that. Every time I heard one clop by, I had to run and see. I couldn't take my eyes off them. Just to watch their skins. The way their necks twist, and sweat shines in the folds . . . *(Pause)* I can't remember when it started. Mum reading to me about Prince who no one could ride, except one boy. Or the white horse in Revelations. 'His eyes were as flames of fire.' Words like reins. Stirrup, Flanks . . . Even the words made me feel – *(pause, Alan's breathing becomes quicker, louder)* The horse is the most naked thing you ever saw! No one understands! . . . except cowboys. They do. I wish I was a cowboy. They're free. No one ever says to cowboys *(mimicking his father)* 'Receive my meaning'! Or 'God' all the time *(mimicking his mother)* 'God sees you, Alan. God's got eyes everywhere – ' *(he stops abruptly, filled with emotion)* I'm not doing any more! . . . . I hate this!

DYSART: **(Pg 106)** Here . . . here . . . Sssh . . . calm now. Breathe in deep. *(Alan complies and takes a couple of calming breaths)* **Pg 66** Good boy. Now, [imagine] you're in your bedroom at home. You're twelve years old. You're looking at Equus from the foot of your bed. Now tell me. Why is Equus in chains?

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ALAN: *(kneeling as before a church altar; he may even cross himself in the Catholic tradition)* For the sins of the world. *(Alan begins praying silently, the audience can see his lips moving, but can't understand any words)*

DYSART: **(Pg 53- 55)** *(listens for a moment then interrupts)* Tell me something. Who introduced you to the stable to begin with?

ALAN: *(rising reluctantly – he'd like to continue his worship)* Someone I met . . . [at] Bryson's.

DYSART: The shop where you worked? *(Alan steps into a flashback scene)*

******* Scene shifts to Alan's first meeting of Jill *******

JILL: Hallo. Have you any blades for a clipping machine? – To clip horses.

ALAN: *(Pause. He stares at her, open mouthed – in awe)* You work at Dalton's Stables.

JILL: *(amused)* You're the boy who's always staring into the yard around lunch-time. Are you looking for a job or something?

ALAN: *(eagerly)* Is there one?

JILL: We can always use extra hands. Can you ride?

ALAN: No . . . No . . . I don't want to.

JILL: *(shrugging her shoulders)* It'd mainly be mucking out. . . . Come up on Saturday. I'll introduce you to Mr. Dalton.

ALAN: **(Pg 57-59)** *(in pantomime, scene shifts to Alan at the stable for the first time – He is lost in wonder. He starts almost involuntarily to kneel on the floor in reverence before the horse stalls, but is interrupted by the cheery voice of Jill. He straightens up guiltily)*

JILL: This is Nugget. He's my favorite. *(she picks up a curry-comb and begins showing Alan how to brush the invisible body of Nugget.)* Don't be afraid to do it hard. The harder you do it, the more the horse loves it. Push it right through the coat: like this. Down towards the tail and right through the coat . . . You try. *(She hands him the brush)*

ALAN: *(embarrassed and excited, he performs his own pantomime, copying her movements and echoing Jill's words reverently)* Nice and easy. Never rush. Down towards the tail and right through the coat.

JILL: You've got a feel for it. I can tell. It's going to be nice teaching you. *(Jill exits)*

ALAN: *(runs his hands over Nugget's flesh. Lifts his palm to his face and smells it deeply, closing his eyes – he is lost in the sensation)*

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DYSART: *(softly interjecting)* Was that good? Touching them.

ALAN: *(with a faint groan)* Mmmm. *(silence as Alan resumes bushing Nugget)*

DYSART: How about the girl? Did you like her? *(silence)* Did you take her out? Come on now: tell me. Did you have a date with her? Tell me if you did.

ALAN: *(Angry at being pulled out of his fantasy; Alan suddenly explodes in a rage – yelling)* TELL ME! ***Tell me, tell me, tell me, tell me!*** On and on, sitting there! Just like Dad. On and on and bloody on! Tell me, tell me tell me! **(Pg 73-74)** *(turning away from Dysart, Alan shifts into his ritual, chanting voice as a way to soothe himself)* Equus – son of Fleckwus – son of Neckwus. The king rides out on Equus, mightiest of horses. *(Alan pantomimes mounting Nugget)* Only I can ride him. Equus, my God-slave! . . . Now the King commands you. *(Alan pantomimes riding Nugget, his voice becoming louder and more forceful; and equally more disturbed)* And Equus the mighty rose against All! His enemies scatter, his enemies fall! Trample them, trample them! **My** flanks! *(rubs the outsides of his thighs)* **My** hooves! *(looks lovingly at his own hands)* Equus -- Bear me away! Make us One Person! *(more and more frantic in his fantasy)* One Person! One Person! *(He rises up on the horse's back and calls like a trumpet)* Ha-HA! . . . . Ha-HA! . . . Ha-HA! *(Silence – slowly Alan dismounts, lowers his head an kneels once again in front of his God, Nugget – his breathing slows, he looks up reverently and cries)* AMEN!!

DYSART: *(interrupting again, softly)* **(pg 88-89)** [Alan], you **are** going to tell me everything that happened with this girl.

ALAN: **(Pg 98)** *(as if in a trance)* The Stables . . .

DYSART: **(Pg 100)** The temple? The Holy of Holies?

******* Scene flashes back to Alan and Jill at the stable *******

JILL: **(Pg 99)** - *(suggestively)* What's the matter? Don't you want to?

ALAN: *(aching to)* Yes! *(desperately fearful as he looks at the horses in their stalls)* Them! . . . Them! . . . *(low)* Horses. *(Alan starts shaking)*

JILL: Look, if the sight of horses offends you, we can just shut the door. You won't have to see them. All right?

ALAN: **(pg 100-102)** *(to Dysart)* What else can I do? . . . I can't say! I can't tell her . . . . *(to Jill)* Lock it!

JILL: It's just an old door. What's the matter with you? They're in their [stalls]. They can't get out.

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ALAN: *(emphatically)* ***Lock it!*** *(to Dysart as he describes the stable)* [It's a] large room. Straw everywhere. Some tools. . . *(picks up a hoof pick)* A hoof pick! *(Alan mentally assesses the stable almost in a trance)* At the end this big door. Behind it. . . *(trembling he can't continue)*

DYSART: *(Dysart helps)* Horses. How many?

ALAN: Six . . . She put her mouth [on] mine. It was lovely! Oh, it was lovely! *(Alan's trembling increase and he begins cry)*

DYSART: *(gently)* What was it? You couldn't? Though you wanted to very much?

ALAN: I couldn't . . . see her. Only Him. Every time I kissed her – HE was in the way . . . No! *(suddenly he crouches in the corner like a beast in a cage)*

JILL: **(Pg 103-104)** Alan. It's all right . . . Don't worry about it. Alan, look at me. Alan?

ALAN: Get out! . . . *(he snatches up the invisible pick)* **GET OUT!**

JILL: Alan . . . *(moving away from him warily)* Listen: you don't have to do anything. Nothing at all. Why don't we just lie here together in the straw. And talk.

ALAN: *(to Dysart)* He was there. Through the door. The door was shut, but he was there! . . . He'd seen everything. I could hear him. He was laughing. *(Alan reverts to his memory and speaks to Equus)* Friend . . . Equus the Kind . . . The Merciful! . . . Forgive me! *(Silence)* **(Pg 105-106)** I'll never do it again. I swear . . . I swear! . . . *(Silence, then in a moan)* Please! *(pause as Alan is overcome with fear)* I see his eyes! They are rolling! *(in the horse's voice)* 'I see you. Always! Everywhere! Forever!' *(Alan's voice in terror)* Eyes! . . . Eyes like flames – coming – coming! God seest! God seest! NO! . . . . *(Collecting himself, Alan moves slowly toward Nugget, the pick concealed behind his back. He strokes Nugget's muzzle, then says gently)* Equus . . . Noble Equus . . . Thou – God – Seest *(long pause)* NOTHING! *(raising the pick, Alan violently stabs out Nugget's eyes, then yelling in hysteria he collapses on the ground, stabbing at his own eyes with the invisible pick)* Find me! . . . Find me! . . . KILL ME!

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2002 National Qualifier
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The jingle for Doublemint Gum can be found here
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=PHfjdxN1URI

**gaoler – Archaic spelling of jailer: a person in charge of a jail or of the prisoners in it.*

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